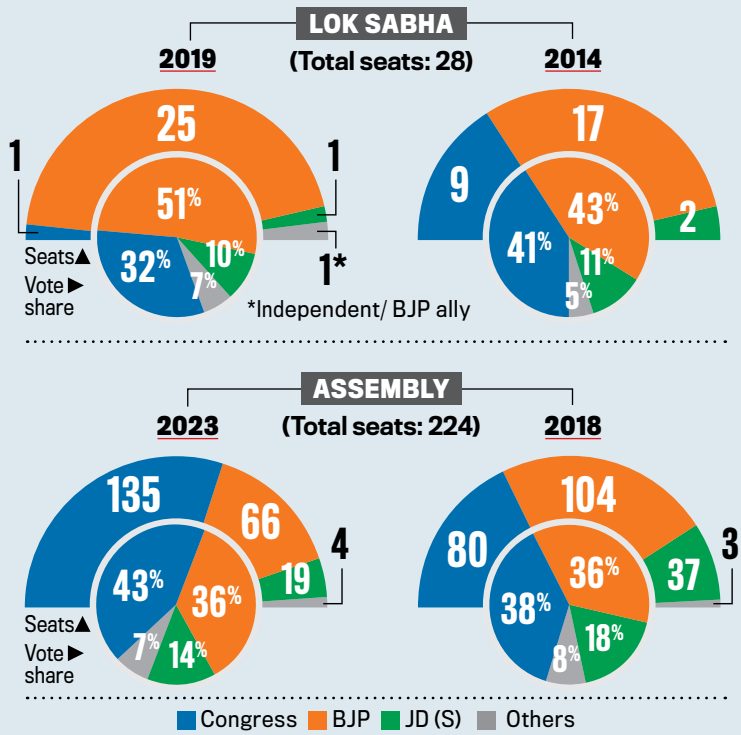


**MOUNTING A CHALLENGE**
Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah and other Congress leaders at a rally in Bengaluru, Mar. 28

# THE KARNATAKA PARADOX

**Its limited luck in assembly polls hasn't marred the BJP's astounding success in parliamentary contests so far**




communities, such as the Veerashaiva-Lingayats who had traditionally backed the BJP. Alongside this, the BJP has entered into a seat-sharing alliance with the Janata Dal (Secular), a party that relies on support from the Vokkaligas, the other major caste group in Karnataka. This attempt at consolidating the dominant castes potentially pushes the Congress to double down on its support base amongst the *Alpasankhyataru* or minorities, *Hindulidavaru* or backward classes, and *Dalitaru* or Dalits—an old assortment known by its Kannada acronym 'Ahinda' and a key plank of Chief Minister Siddaramaiah's campaign.

The BJP's biggest strength, however, remains the popularity of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "The advantages the BJP had in the last election are still there," notes political